



How low will PC prices go? Is a \$100 PC a dream? Will computing for the masses ever become a reality? The experts and professionals speak out

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If you are reading this, you are probably on the happy side of the Digital Divide—a term that's been bandied about too long, but which is nevertheless increasing in importance, especially in developing countries such as India. Think about it: on the other side of the Divide, just about five million of India's 1,200 million people own a PC, and only two million are connected to the Internet. What factors are responsible for these sad figures? Will they change? And what is being done about it?

\$100. That's the price Steve Ballmer's vision dictates for an affordable computer in poorer countries such as India; and that is supposed to include the \$30 for Windows XP Starter Edition. This is well in keeping with Bill Gates' statement of long ago that hardware would effectively be free at some point. Of course, Starter Edition is crippleware, and one wonders why Microsoft didn't simply downprice the Home Edition instead of coming up with a new edition altogether—but that is not the issue. The point is, is \$70 for the hardware feasible?

As much at issue is the question of what use computers are being put to anyway, whatever the price point.

Bytesforall.org is a portal that discusses, and brings together people interested in, the question of computing for the masses in South Asia. Frederick Noronha, co-founder, is of the opinion that "while PCs and IT have so much power, we're pushed into using them in entirely wasteful ways and in a manner that hardly addresses basic human problems." It is a fact that the typical home computer amongst the digitally wealthy is most used for games and other entertainment; next comes communication and Web surfing; and other uses, such as education, rank a distant third. But thinking about those on the other side of the Divide, what use is a PC?

Essentially, communication and education. These are two areas where computers can genuinely empower people. Ashok Jhunjhunwala of IIT-Madras has long had a vision in this direction.

Ashok Jhunjhunwala's Vision

Going by the figures, we need an urgent solution to the problem of the Divide. Noronha says, "It will not necessarily be in terms of cheaper individual PCs, but in terms of sharable computing, reused computers, whatever." Revisiting the question of what computers are being, and will be, used for, Noronha says: "People need to be using PCs effectively for their purposes. As of now,